

spread the rents through house price inflation. However, there has always been a sizable part of the population who has rented. Given how high house prices are relative to incomes, it is hard to believe that homeownership has much room for expansion. In many cities we now see the opposite movement towards renting. While

rental homes were often provided (to a substantial degree) by public or nonprofit housing, they are now mostly provided by for-profit actors. That concentrates rents at the very top of the wealth distribution (who receive rent payments and the capital gains) and squeezes renters. An equitable and stable housing system needs nonprofit actors. ■

SKILL COMPOSITION AND OCCUPATIONAL MOBILITY: AN INTERVIEW WITH MARIE LABUSSIÈRE

Marie Labussière is an Assistant Professor at the Centre for Research on Social Inequalities (CRIS) at Sciences Po. Her research examines the links between social stratification and technological change. Drawing on computational methods and large-scale labor market data, she studies the evolution of skills in the labor market, the effects of technological change on wage inequalities and career trajectories, and the ways in which artificial intelligence reshapes social relations at work.

Yasemin Girgin, a Ph.D. student in Sociology at Boston University, spoke with Dr. Labussière about her recent research on skill composition within and between occupations, and what skill profiles reveal about the structure of the labor market and pathways of occupational mobility.

Yasemin Girgin: Thank you so much for joining us in this issue. Could you tell us a bit about your academic trajectory? How did you come to study sociology, and what drew you to questions of labor market inequalities?

Marie Labussière: I discovered sociology during a multidisciplinary bachelor's program, and I still remember struggling to make sense of Marx, Weber, and Bourdieu, while finding it very stimulating to uncover the mechanisms behind the production and reproduction of social inequalities. But my path to becoming a sociologist was actually quite a winding one. I first graduated from ENSAE Paris, a French *Grande École* specializing in economics, statistics, and data science, where sociology courses were few and far between. Yet this quantitative training ended up shaping my approach to sociological questions and, in particular, my interest in exploring new data and methods.

My interest in labor market inequalities also emerged somewhat serendipitously, as my Ph.D. was not focused on this topic. It was during my postdoc that I discovered this field, through a research project on the interplay between labor market transformations and workers' careers. As I started digging into this literature, I was struck by how often skills, educational attainment, and occupations were conflated. While some scholars have questioned the construction and use of occupations since at least the 1950s—think of Theodore Caplow or Harry Braverman—these categories have remained remarkably stable. This is partly due to the lack of detailed data on the skills and tasks involved in different jobs, but I also felt that we still needed a better conceptual understanding of what skills are and how they relate to other key dimensions of labor market inequality, such as education, occupation, and social background.

I therefore became interested in moving beyond the idea of skills as neutral characteristics and in understanding how the ways we define and measure them may encode social hierarchies. And having access to a rich source of online job ad data with granular information on skill requirements, I began to think that, before asking how labor markets were changing, we first needed to ask whether we were using the right tools to measure those changes.

Y. G.: Your recent *Sociological Science* article with Thijs Bol challenges the common assumption in labor market research that occupations can be treated as relatively coherent “bundles of skills.” Instead, you ask us to look more closely at the combinations of skills required in jobs. What do we lose when we focus on either individual skill dimensions in isolation, or infer skill requirements from occupations, rather than examining how skills are combined?

M. L.: When we measure the skill content of jobs by focusing on a few isolated skill dimensions, we overlook the fact that jobs are bundles of different tasks requiring different combinations of skills. Some skills may be valuable in themselves because they are rare or difficult to acquire, but their value is also relational and context-dependent. For example, advanced programming skills may command a much higher wage premium when combined with the ability to interact effectively with clients or explain technical concepts to non-specialists. A growing body of research using network analysis has highlighted these patterns of complementarity: some skills derive much of their value from the other skills they are paired with, while others enhance the value of a broader set of skills by making it more versatile or distinctive. In the paper, we use the notion of a *skill profile* to capture these combinations of skills at the job level, on the premise that they have properties that cannot be inferred from individual skills alone.

Beyond the multidimensionality of skills, another crucial aspect is the level at which skills are measured. When we infer skill requirements from occupational classifications, we typically overlook



the heterogeneity of skills *within* occupations, treating this variation as idiosyncratic differences between jobs that have little relevance for labor market outcomes. Yet, a growing body of research suggests that occupational boundaries are much more porous than we tend to assume: workers frequently move across occupations over the course of their careers, while their own perceptions of their position does not always align neatly with occupational hierarchies. This led us to ask whether these porous boundaries reflect similarities in the skill profiles of jobs that are masked with coarse occupational proxies. A guiding question of our paper was therefore to analyze how skill profiles vary both between and within occupations.

Y. G.: You use job postings in the United Kingdom and topic modeling to identify latent skill profiles. Could you walk our readers through your methodological strategy? What does using real job postings and natural language processing allow you to observe in the organization of skills that occupation-based measures would miss?

M. L.: The methodological strategy was driven by a desire to develop a measure of skill profiles that is closely aligned with the conceptual idea that skills are multidimensional and interdependent. Rather than assuming in advance which dimensions of

skills matter most, we use a bottom-up, data-driven approach to identify the skill configurations that actually emerge from the labor market.

More specifically, we analyze the co-occurrence of skill requirements within individual job postings using topic modeling. This allows us to identify latent skill profiles—patterns of skills that tend to be demanded together across jobs—without imposing predefined categories on the data. While this approach may appear atheoretical at first glance, it is actually grounded in a sociological critique of the categories we commonly use to think about skills. Many conventional distinctions, such as blue-collar versus white-collar or manual versus non-manual work, are not neutral descriptions of skill content; they are historically constructed categories that often reflect and reproduce assumptions about the social value of different types of work. Examining how skills are combined in practice therefore helps us move beyond normative classifications that categorize jobs according to their social prestige rather than their actual skill content—and that often use skill requirements to retrospectively justify these hierarchies.

Actual job postings are an asset for identifying skill profiles because they contain granular information about skill requirements and provide insight into how skills are organized and recognized, as articulated by employers themselves. Rather than treating job postings as transparent reflections of skills, we view them as evidence of the demand side of the labor market, revealing how employers define, combine, and value different skills. This perspective is important because employers play a central role in determining which skills are recognized and rewarded. While there are likely many biases in how job ads are constructed, they nevertheless provide a systematic empirical basis for analyzing employers' skill requirements.

Y. G.: One of the striking findings of the paper is that skill profiles do not map neatly onto occupational boundaries; there is substantial skill heterogeneity within occupations, and also skill similarity across occupations. How should this finding

change the way we think about labor market structure and the organization of inequality?

M. L.: We indeed find that skill and occupational boundaries are misaligned, and that skill boundaries are meaningful for understanding labor market wage inequality: skill profiles provide additional explanatory power for differences in offered wage across job ads, even when accounting for the most detailed 4-digit level of occupational classifications. These findings show the need to go beyond unidimensional measures of human capital to explain why some workers earn more than others. With the same level of education and years of experience, some workers may develop an advantage in the labor market because they were able to acquire valuable combinations of skills over the course of their careers. This suggests that understanding wage inequality requires paying attention not only to workers' formal qualifications and current occupation, but also to the ways in which they gradually accumulate different skill combinations and convert them into labor market advantages.

Beyond wages, the observed patterns of skill (dis)similarity also suggest new ways of thinking about inequalities in occupational mobility. Research has taken a keen interest in analyzing the transferability of skills to explain why some workers are more (upwardly) mobile than others, yet common measures often neglect both the multidimensionality of skills and their heterogeneity within occupations. A skill profile approach would allow us to examine how the transferability of skills depends on the combinations in which they are embedded, and how these configurations shape mobility pathways across occupations. It is likely, however, that workers cannot equally leverage the skills they possess, as mobility opportunities are also shaped by organizational and institutional factors. Understanding these processes can help explain how skill-based inequalities intersect with other dimensions of inequality.

Y. G.: If occupations are not bundles of skills, what do contemporary occupational boundaries actually capture? More broadly, how might your framework help us think about the relative importance of factors beyond skill composition; such as

jurisdictional claims, symbolic distinctions, and institutionalized forms of recognition; in shaping occupational boundaries, market positions, and the inequalities they sustain?

M. L.: Another important finding from the paper is that occupational categories remain important for explaining differences in offered wages across job ads, even when the skill content of jobs is comprehensively measured. Our argument is therefore not that occupations no longer matter, but rather that we should investigate the reasons why occupations matter beyond their skill composition. Fortunately, there is a long research tradition that conceptualizes occupations more broadly as institutional units, highlighting the institutional and symbolic barriers that occupational groups erect to secure advantages for their incumbents.

Occupational closure, licensing, and educational credentials can all contribute to making certain occupations more highly rewarded than others, even when they are qualitatively similar in terms of skill requirements. Another related dimension is occupational prestige, which can lead similar skills to be valued differently depending on the occupations in which they are used. This is particularly salient for occupations often perceived as “manual,” even when they involve substantial technical expertise and cognitive skills. Take plumbers, repairers, or mechanics: their jobs often involve problem solving, logical reasoning, experiential knowledge, and practical creativity, but these skills are rarely recognized and rewarded to the same extent as when they are used in higher-status occupations.

Now that we can separately measure skills and occupations, an important next step is to analyze how skills interact with occupational boundaries: whether and how they reinforce, weaken, or legitimize socioeconomic inequalities between occupational groups.

Y. G.: Looking ahead, do you think advances in AI will make occupations increasingly similar in terms of the skill combinations they require, creating a more convergent skill structure across the

labor market? Or are we more likely to see the emergence of new occupational boundaries built around novel and differentiated skill profiles?

M. L.: I find it difficult to speculate about what AI, and especially generative AI, will change in practice and over the long term, particularly because we still lack a comprehensive understanding of how skill profiles co-evolve with technological change, within and across occupational boundaries. There are many studies examining how technology changes the salience and value of particular tasks and skills, but we still know relatively little about which characteristics of skill profiles matter most in changing labor markets. For example, do workers benefit from broad or specialized skill profiles, and how does this vary across the occupational spectrum?

What seems clear, however, is that generative AI pushes us to move beyond older skill categories and dichotomies, as it is beginning to reshape forms of professional, highly skilled, and well-paid work by automating tasks that were long assumed to require uniquely human expertise. Understanding who will be able to leverage new technologies, or transition to new occupations if their jobs are disrupted, requires looking at workers’ full skill profiles rather than isolated skills or occupational categories.

At the same time, this is not only a question of identifying which skill combinations are advantageous in a changing labor market, but also of understanding how technological change reshapes the organization of work and the distribution of power within organizations. In the paper, we focus on wage differences, but future research could connect skill profiles to broader dimensions of workplace stratification, such as workers’ autonomy and bargaining power. As AI changes how knowledge and expertise are distributed, it becomes important to examine not only which skills are rewarded, but also how skill profiles interact with organizational positions to shape workers’ agency in the face of new technologies. ■